

LOCAL NEWS AUGUST 6, 2010

LIBRARY COLUMN: Bookdrop fire had an upside, but not encouraged again



George Williams



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I spent the day of July 5 dealing with the aftermath of a fire that had been started in the outside bookdrop at the Moscow Public Library. Sometime in the evening on Independence Day someone placed lit fireworks in the drop. Fortunately the fire was contained within the bookdrop box and didn't spread to the large tree overhead.

Instead of doing my normal job, I became a library investigator. I spent the day sifting through a charred pile of books, trying to find enough information about them that I could check them in and none of our library patrons would be charged late fees on books that had been destroyed by vandalism. Then I began investigating how to replace and repair the equipment that had also been damaged.

By the end of that day, I was able to identify 49 library items that had been destroyed: 39 children's books, four adult books, two audiobooks and 10 DVDs. It was fortunately a small number due to the fact we had emptied the bookdrop on the afternoon of the Fourth.

I looked at the damaged equipment. The bookdrop box had severe smoke damage, but the bin that sits inside of the box to catch returned materials needed to be replaced. It had several moving pieces of plastic and aluminum that were melted in the fire. I hoped a good cleaning would remove the smoke smell from the box, but the bookdrop service had to be closed until we could scrounge up some replacement equipment and get the box deodorized.

To put it succinctly, the fire sucked. During the month of July, it cost the library at least 39 hours in lost work, more than \$2,600 in lost equipment, about \$1,250 in repairs and close to \$1,000 in destroyed library materials. Thanks to the help of

the Moscow police, we had what we needed to start an insurance claim, but the fire caused a lot of inconvenience for library patrons and extra work for staff.

As it turned out, however, there was an upside. On July 6, we had inquiries from the Daily News, KLEW and Inland Northwest Radio News, all of whom ran stories about the fire. When the community learned about the incident, there was huge support. People of all ages offered donations of books and cash. Others offered to organize fundraising. The Friends of the Library stepped forward. Neill Public Library in Pullman donated new children's materials for our collection as well as the support of their entire staff.

Just as importantly, not having a working bookdrop for a few weeks reminded our staff and our patrons just how much people rely on it. In the 30 minutes I've been sitting outside of the library writing this column, I've seen at least 10 cars pull up to drop materials off outside. We probably have 200-300 items returned to the bookdrop each day. Not having this service for most of July impacted many people.

The publicity and support were fantastic, but perhaps the most significant thing the publicity did is it inspired the vandal who committed the crime to come forward. We now know who put the lit fireworks into the bookdrop and he is planning to reimburse the library for the expense his thoughtless act caused.

In the end we had the dropbox repainted. The repainting process took care of the smoke smell inside as well as wear and tear on the outside, including damage we had caused ourselves with all our informational signs about the fire. So as you come around the corner on Jefferson in Moscow, and your headlights hit the yellow reflective letters that spell out "Book Return," please be sure to stop by and drop off your library returns. But please, no more fireworks.

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